Critical Reflection: *Harris and Battle (2013)*

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Harris and Battle's (2013) study *Unpacking Civic Engagement: The Sociopolitical Involvement of Same-Gender-Loving Black Women* Examines how belonging shapes political participation, while Cathy Cohen's *The Boundaries of Blackness*, argues that intragroup marginalization limits access to belonging within black communities (Cohen 1999). If Harris and Battle's study were replicated using Black transgender women, the relationship between belonging and participation would likely be weaker or differently structured because intragroup marginalization limits trans individual's access to belonging within both LGBT and Black communities.

In Harris and Battle's study, the authors test how sense of belonging and comfort within Black and LGBTQ contexts affect sociopolitical participation among Black SGL women. Sociopolitical participation in the study refers to a range of civic activities, including political engagement, community organizing, and issue-based involvement. They find that connection to the LGBT community and connection to the POC community increase participation, while comfort in the LGBT community decreases participation (Harris and Battle 2013). Their results imply that connection to a community drives participation. This model relies on individual access to community spaces to develop connections that drive participation.

Cohen's concept of secondary marginalization demonstrates that marginalized communities enforce internal boundaries through respectability politics, excluding individuals who do not conform to dominant norms. These boundaries produce hierarchies structured by intersecting identities such as race, gender, and sexuality (Cohen 1999). As a result, belonging to LGBT or POC spaces is not equally accessible to all members, but is shaped by political processes of inclusion and exclusion. This framework applies to Black trans women, who encounter transphobia in Black communities and both racism and transphobia within LGBT spaces.

This form of secondary marginalization constrains Black trans women's access to belonging. In Harris and Battle (2013), belonging is the primary factor that connects individuals to political activity within their communities. When access to communities is challenged, belonging decreases, and the connection between belonging and participation will weaken. This occurs because boundary-making and

respectability politics create internal structures that exclude transgender identities that do not conform to hetero-normative standards (Cohen 1999). Fewer opportunities to form connections to LGBT or POC communities reduce the positive effect of community connection on participation. Participation for trans women is affected by legal barriers such as voter ID laws, and limited institutional access may shift participation towards more informal or mutual aid organizing instead of formal voting or interaction with institutions.

Future research could replicate Harris and Battle's study using Black transgender women by measuring belonging through connection and comfort and examining its relationship to participation in LGBT and Black contexts. To further test Cohen's framework, additional variables should capture perceived inclusion and exclusion within these communities. Participation should be divided into institutional forms, such as voting and organizational involvement, and informal forms, such as mutual aid and grassroots organizing. This research would test three hypotheses: (1) connection to the LGBT community and connection to POC communities increase participation, but the effect is smaller for Black trans women than for SGL women; (2) comfort within the LGBT community remains negatively associated with participation; and (3) perceived secondary marginalization mediates the relationship between connection and participation, weakening the positive relationship observed among SGL women.

Harris and Battle showed that belonging, particularly connection to LGBT or POC communities, drives sociopolitical participation among Black SGL women. Cohen demonstrates that belonging itself is shaped by intragroup marginalization, respectability politics, and internal hierarchies, which affects who belongs to marginalized communities. Because Black trans women face exclusion within both Black and LGBT spaces, their access to belonging is constrained, weakening the belonging-participation relationship. As a result, participation among Black trans women is less likely to occur through institutional methods and more likely to take informal forms.

References

Cohen, Cathy J. 1999. “Enter AIDS: Context and Confrontation.” In *Boundaries of Blackness: AIDS and the Breakdown of Black Politics*. University of Chicago Press.

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